THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER TEN

“PAGE FORTY”

August 10, 2009 – January 18, 2010
New York • Bel Air • Beverly Hills • View Park

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

FADE IN:

INT. MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT - EXECUTIVE OFFICES - 417 FIFTH AVENUE, NEW YORK CITY - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, AUGUST 10, 2009 - 7:00 A.M. EDT

Not a palace. A plain conference room with gray carpet, a laminate table, and a water cooler that gurgles. Framed on the wall: a copy of FANTASTIC FOUR #1 and a faded 1990s stock certificate from the bankruptcy era. There are no snacks. There is tap water in paper cups.

Across the table from each other sit two people who have never met.

NATASHA BULLOCK (48), in a navy suit, is the most powerful CEO in entertainment. Across from her sits IKE PERLMUTTER, the famously private chairman of Marvel Entertainment, a man who almost never gives interviews and has been known to retrieve paper clips from the trash. He is in his sixties, in a plain sport coat.

A single lawyer sits beside each of them. Otherwise, the room is empty.

PERLMUTTER
You came alone. No entourage. No assistant. I appreciate that.

NATASHA
You said seven a.m. and no assistants. I took the red-eye.

PERLMUTTER
In coach?

NATASHA
(a beat)
First class.

PERLMUTTER
(shaking his head slightly)
That's the difference between us, Mrs. Bullock. I've been flying coach since 1985.

NATASHA
And I own the airline's in-flight entertainment contract. We all have our hobbies.

A long silence. Then, unexpectedly, Perlmutter almost smiles.

PERLMUTTER
Tell me why I should sell you my company.

NATASHA
Because Marvel is the most valuable library of characters ever created and you're running it with five hundred and twenty-five million dollars of borrowed money that now belongs to Bank of America. Because the next ten years of your slate depend on credit markets that froze solid eleven months ago. Because Fox owns your mutants, Sony owns your spider, and you need someone with enough money and enough patience to get them back.

(beat)
And because I'm the only buyer who won't touch a thing.

PERLMUTTER
Everyone says that.

NATASHA
Everyone isn't the mother of your Iron Man.

Perlmutter leans back.

PERLMUTTER
Ah. There it is.

NATASHA
My son walked into your studio in 2006 without a single phone call from me. My daughter walked in the next year and lied to my face to do it. They built your first four movies with their own hands. If I buy Marvel and change one thing, I'll be telling my own children they didn't earn it.

(sliding a single sheet of paper across the table)
So I won't change anything. Kevin Feige keeps the studio. Marvel keeps its name, its offices and its creative control. And Donohue retires the Bank of America facility on the day we close. Captain America will never be collateral again.

Perlmutter reads the number on the page. He doesn't react. He reads it again.

PERLMUTTER
Four billion.

NATASHA
Thirty dollars a share in cash. Twenty dollars a share in Donohue stock. Fifty dollars a share. Your shareholders get a forty percent premium. You become one of the largest individual shareholders in Donohue Entertainment.

PERLMUTTER
(quiet)
And the Smilley girl? Your rivals' daughter. She is my Thor.

Natasha's expression doesn't change.

NATASHA
She auditioned four hundred and twelve times against the best actresses in the world and won. She's your Thor. She'll be my Thor. Marvel cast her. Donohue doesn't uncast anyone.

Perlmutter stares at her for a long time. Then he picks up his paper cup of tap water and holds it out across the table.

PERLMUTTER
I'll need two weeks.

Natasha picks up her own paper cup. They tap them together.

NATASHA
You'll have three.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - FEIGE'S OFFICE - BEVERLY HILLS - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, AUGUST 27, 2009 - 9:40 P.M. PDT

Downstairs, the Mercedes dealership is dark. KEVIN FEIGE (36) sits alone at his desk with an IRON MAN 2 storyboard. His BlackBerry buzzes: "PERLMUTTER." He answers.

FEIGE
Ike. Hi.

He listens. His face goes slowly pale. He stands up. He sits down again.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
...Donohue?

(listening)
Monday. Before the market opens.

(listening, his voice tight)
And the studio? Ike, the studio...

A long pause. Feige closes his eyes.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
She said that? In writing?

(beat)
Okay. Okay. Thank you for telling me.

He hangs up. Sits for a long moment in the dark office. Then he picks up his desk phone.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
Lenora. I need you to come back to the office. Bring the NDA folder. No, the big one.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - FEIGE'S OFFICE - LATER

SUPER: THURSDAY, AUGUST 27, 2009 - 10:30 P.M. PDT

LENORA HAYES (44), in sweats and a Dodgers cap, sits across from Feige, reading the confidential term sheet.

LENORA
Four billion dollars.

FEIGE
Four billion.

LENORA
(still reading, stunned)
And she retires the Bank of America debt at closing. Lord, Kevin. The bank doesn't own Cap anymore.

FEIGE
The bank doesn't own Cap anymore.

Lenora puts the term sheet down.

LENORA
You know what this looks like. The richest family in Hollywood just bought the universe their son and daughter star in. Everything we fought for. Every audition. Every "he earned it in the room." The Gerald Whitfield thing. The Pepper leak. It all goes out the window. People are going to say Donohue bought it for them.

FEIGE
People are going to say that.

LENORA
And the Smilley girl? Her father has spent forty years making sure no Smilley ever works on a Donohue production. As of Monday, his daughter works for Natasha Bullock.

Feige looks out the window at the dark Beverly Hills street.

FEIGE
In 2006 I put a promise in writing. "Faithful. Nobody gets nerfed." Lenora, I'm going to put another one in writing on Monday.

LENORA
Which is?

FEIGE
Nobody at Donohue touches a casting decision. Ever. Not for the Bullocks. Not against the Smilleys. Not for anyone.

LENORA
You think Natasha Bullock will agree to that?

FEIGE
(picking up the term sheet, pointing at a clause)
She already did. It's on page forty.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE - FORMAL DINING ROOM - BEL AIR - NIGHT

SUPER: SUNDAY, AUGUST 30, 2009 - 7:30 P.M. PDT

Sunday family dinner. A long candlelit table. VICTOR (73) at the head. JOAN (71) at his right. ROBERT (50), ELXA (29, two days into the year), GRACE (15), and MARC-ANTHONY (27). A cake with "HAPPY BIRTHDAY ELXA" sits half-eaten on a side table.

NATASHA (48) sets down her fork. The table quiets. Robert, who knows what's coming, takes her hand under the table.

NATASHA
I need to tell you all something before the rest of the world finds out. Tomorrow morning at five a.m. our time, Donohue Entertainment will announce that it has agreed to acquire Marvel Entertainment. Four billion dollars.

Silence. Grace's mouth falls open. Elxa sets down her wine glass very slowly. Marc-Anthony doesn't move at all.

GRACE
We're buying IRON MAN?

NATASHA
We're buying Marvel, sweetheart. All of it. Five thousand characters.

GRACE
(turning to her brother, thrilled)
Marc! Mom is buying you!

Marc-Anthony still hasn't moved. He's looking at his mother.

MARC-ANTHONY
(very quietly)
How long have you known?

NATASHA
I started thinking about it eleven months ago. During the crash.

MARC-ANTHONY
Eleven months.

NATASHA
Baby...

MARC-ANTHONY
Eleven months, and you're telling me fourteen hours before the press release.

He puts down his napkin. Stands. Walks to the window and stands with his back to the table, looking out at the dark lawn.

ELXA
(quietly)
Mom. You knew what this would mean to him.

NATASHA
I know exactly what it means to him. That's why I'm doing it.

Victor watches his grandson's back.

VICTOR
Marc-Anthony. Come sit down.

MARC-ANTHONY
(not turning)
Do you remember what you said, Granddad? The morning they announced me. Elxa told me. You read the Variety at five a.m. like a "civilized man," and you said, "Marvel. Not ours. Good. Let him have something that isn't ours."

Victor goes very still.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
(turning around, his eyes wet)
It was the only thing in my whole life that wasn't ours. My first commercial was for Donohueland. My first show was on the Donohue Channel. Every door I've ever walked through, somebody whispered "that's Victor's grandson." Marvel was the one place where nobody cared. Where Jon Favreau looked at me like I was a man and not a last name.

(beat, voice breaking)
And now it's ours.

The room is silent. Grace looks down at her plate, chastened. Natasha stands and crosses to her son.

NATASHA
Look at me.

He does.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
In September of 2008, the economy collapsed. Merrill Lynch disappeared overnight. A bank in North Carolina that had never heard of Tony Stark suddenly owned Captain America. Do you know how close Marvel came to losing everything? Do you know what Warner Bros. would have done with your universe? What Fox would have done? Kevin's job, Jon's job, Esther Smilley's Thor, your sister's Wasp. Gone, to whoever had the most cash.

MARC-ANTHONY
So you bought it.

NATASHA
So I made sure nobody else could. Tomorrow, Donohue pays off every penny of that bank debt. Kevin Feige keeps the studio. Marvel keeps its name, its offices, its creative control. And page forty of the agreement says that no one at Donohue, including me, will ever have any say in who gets cast in a Marvel film. Ever.

(beat)
I didn't buy you a universe, Marc. You built it. I bought the walls so nobody could knock it down.

Marc-Anthony looks at his mother for a long moment.

MARC-ANTHONY
Nobody at Donohue touches a casting decision?

NATASHA
Nobody.

MARC-ANTHONY
Not for me. Not for Elxa. Not for Grace.

(beat, very careful)
Not against anyone.

Natasha studies her son. Something in the way he says "anyone" catches her attention.

NATASHA
...Anyone?

MARC-ANTHONY
Anyone. Including people this family doesn't like.

A long silence. Natasha's sharp eyes narrow slightly. Joan, at the table, looks up from her coffee at her grandson.

NATASHA
Including people this family doesn't like.

(beat)
Nobody gets uncast, baby. You have my word.

Marc-Anthony nods slowly. He wraps his arms around his mother. Over his shoulder, Natasha's eyes meet Victor's. The old man raises his glass slightly. Learn from my mistakes. She did.

GRACE
(small voice)
So... we're still buying Iron Man, right?

Everyone laughs. The tension breaks.

VICTOR
Gracie, my love. We're buying the whole damn Avengers.

CUT TO:

INT. MARC-ANTHONY'S CAR - SUNSET BOULEVARD - NIGHT

SUPER: SUNDAY, AUGUST 30, 2009 - 10:15 P.M. PDT

Marc-Anthony drives east, the lights of the Strip sliding past. He presses a button on the steering wheel. "Call Pastor Williams." It rings. And rings.

ESTHER (V.O.)
(whispering)
It's late. Are you okay?

MARC-ANTHONY
Are you somewhere you can talk?

ESTHER (V.O.)
The closet. Where else.

MARC-ANTHONY
I need to tell you something before you read it at breakfast. You can't tell anyone until five a.m.

ESTHER (V.O.)
Okay.

MARC-ANTHONY
My mother is buying Marvel.

Silence on the line. A very long silence.

ESTHER (V.O.)
(barely audible)
...Oh, God.

MARC-ANTHONY
Nobody at Donohue can touch casting. It's in the contract. Page forty. I made her promise. Nobody gets uncast. Nobody.

ESTHER (V.O.)
Marc. My father has spent his entire life making sure no Smilley ever works for your family. And at five o'clock tomorrow morning...

MARC-ANTHONY
...you'll work for Kevin Feige. Same as yesterday. Same as me.

ESTHER (V.O.)
(a shaky laugh)
You really believe that?

MARC-ANTHONY
I made my mother say it twice. In front of my grandfather.

A beat.

ESTHER (V.O.)
(softly)
You did that for me.

MARC-ANTHONY
(very quietly)
I'd do a lot of things for you.

The silence on the line changes. It's not shock anymore.

ESTHER (V.O.)
...Drive safe, Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY
Goodnight, Your Majesty.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT / MARVEL - NEWS WIRE - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, AUGUST 31, 2009 - 5:00 A.M. PDT (8:00 A.M. EDT)

DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT, INC. - PRESS RELEASE - AUGUST 31, 2009, 8:00 AM ET

DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT TO ACQUIRE MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT FOR $4 BILLION

Marvel Studios to Remain Independent Under Kevin Feige; Donohue to Retire Marvel's Film Credit Facility at Closing

BURBANK, Calif. and NEW YORK - Donohue Entertainment, Inc. (NYSE: DNE) and Marvel Entertainment, Inc. (NYSE: MVL) today announced a definitive agreement under which Donohue will acquire Marvel in a cash and stock transaction valued at approximately $4 billion, or $50 per Marvel share.

Under the terms of the agreement, Marvel shareholders will receive $30 in cash plus $20 in Donohue stock for each Marvel share. Marvel Studios will continue to operate from its current offices under the leadership of Kevin Feige, with full creative control over its films. As a condition of the agreement, Donohue Entertainment and its executives will have no role in casting decisions for any Marvel production.

"Marvel's artists and filmmakers have built something extraordinary, and they did it on their own," said Natasha Donohue Bullock, Chief Executive Officer of Donohue Entertainment. "Our job is not to change Marvel. It's to protect it. Starting today, no bank will ever again hold Marvel's heroes as collateral."

"This agreement gives Marvel the resources to complete the vision we have been building since 2006," said Ike Perlmutter, Chairman of Marvel Entertainment.

The transaction is expected to close by the end of the calendar year, subject to Marvel shareholder approval and regulatory review.

CNBC - "SQUAWK BOX" - MONDAY, AUGUST 31, 2009, 8:12 AM ET - ON-SCREEN GRAPHIC

BREAKING: DONOHUE TO BUY MARVEL FOR $4B - MVL SHARES SURGE 27% PRE-MARKET - DNE DOWN 3%

CUT TO:

INT. SUPERHERO HYPE - THE INTERNET - MORNING

SUPER: MONDAY, AUGUST 31, 2009 - 5:05 A.M. TO 9:00 A.M. PDT

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "DONOHUE BUYS MARVEL FOR $4 BILLION" (Page 1 of 703)

first! (Aug 31, 5:06 AM)
first

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Aug 31, 5:07 AM)
WHAT. WHAT. DONOHUE BOUGHT MARVEL. IS THIS REAL??

Repulsor_Ray (Aug 31, 5:10 AM)
So the Bullock family literally owns the MCU now. Marc-Anthony's MOM is his boss. His SISTER is a founding Avenger. This is the most nepotism thing that has ever nepotismed, and I said that in 2006 and I take back NOTHING.

NoNerfsPlz (Aug 31, 5:15 AM)
Read the press release. "Donohue Entertainment and its executives will have no role in casting decisions." Feige keeps the studio. They pay off the bank debt. This isn't Donohue taking over. This is Donohue building a wall around it.

ThorOdinson4Ever (Aug 31, 5:22 AM)
Are they going to make it Smilley-safe? Mickey ears on Mjolnir? Are we getting a Donohue Channel Thor with musical numbers?

ShellHead1963 (Aug 31, 5:40 AM)
Calm down, everyone. Donohue owns ESPN and nobody thinks SportsCenter is a cartoon. They own Pixar and left it alone. They own Miramax. Donohue is ruthless but it isn't stupid. You don't buy the most successful film studio of the decade and then break it.

WarMachineRox (Aug 31, 6:10 AM)
Bigger question: ESTHER SMILLEY. The Smilleys have refused to work with Donohue for FORTY YEARS. Her dad is going to lose his mind. Is she going to quit Thor??

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Aug 31, 6:15 AM)
Bigger bigger question: Donohue has more money than God. Does this mean they can buy back Spider-Man from Sony? The X-Men from Fox???

NoNerfsPlz (Aug 31, 6:20 AM)
...oh my god. The Rights Reservation thing. Marvel's been keeping the mutants alive in the background since 2006. With Donohue's money... they could come home someday.

Mjolnir_Worthy (Aug 31, 7:44 AM)
Real talk: Marvel just went from a company that had to borrow money with Captain America as collateral to a company owned by the richest corporation on Earth. Thor got moved to 2011 because of the crash. That never happens again.

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (UNITED STATES) - MONDAY, AUGUST 31, 2009

#DonohueMarvel - Natasha Bullock - $4 Billion - Mickey Iron Man - Esther Smilley - Kevin Feige

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

gammagal: so marc-anthony bullock's mom just bought his job. i love him but come ON 5:30 AM Aug 31st from web

hallhpriya: read the release. "no role in casting decisions." the bank debt is gone. as a physicist: this is the most stable the mcu has ever been. as a fan: please don't put mickey ears on thor 6:01 AM Aug 31st from txt

amondbaker: i knew nothing about this. for once in my life i actually knew nothing. it feels great 7:15 AM Aug 31st from web

marcanthonyb: to everyone asking: i found out last night at dinner. i still work for kevin. so does everyone else. nobody gets nerfed. nobody gets uncast 8:40 AM Aug 31st from web

TUMBLR - "MARVELMEMES" - MONDAY, AUGUST 31, 2009 - 14,882 notes

[Image: The Iron Man helmet photoshopped with Mickey Mouse ears. Caption: "I AM IRON MOUSE."]

[Image: Mjolnir with a tiny Donohueland price tag. Caption: "WHOSOEVER HOLDS THIS HAMMER, IF SHE HAS AN ANNUAL PASS..."]

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL STUDIOS - SECOND FLOOR BULLPEN - BEVERLY HILLS - DAY

SUPER: MONDAY, AUGUST 31, 2009 - 9:30 A.M. PDT

Every Marvel Studios employee, maybe sixty people, is crammed into the main open-plan workspace: production coordinators, VFX supervisors, the receptionist, the guy who runs the mail room. Concept art on every wall. Everyone is nervous. Everyone has read the news.

Feige stands on a chair at the front of the room. Lenora stands beside him.

FEIGE
Okay. Everybody. I know you've all read it. I know some of you are scared. I was scared too. On Thursday night, I sat in my office in the dark for an hour.

(beat)
She's here. She asked to talk to you herself.

The stairwell door opens. Natasha Bullock walks in. No entourage. No assistant. Just Natasha, in a simple black suit, carrying nothing.

Sixty people stare at the most powerful woman in Hollywood, standing in a room above a car dealership. Downstairs, faintly, a salesman's voice: "...and this one has the panoramic sunroof..."

Natasha looks around the room at the concept art: Asgard, Captain America's shield, the Mark IV armor, a sketch of Janet van Dyne's wings. Then at the people.

NATASHA
Good morning. I'm Natasha. I don't do speeches before ten, so I'll keep this short.

(beat)
In 2006, you borrowed five hundred and twenty-five million dollars and put Captain America up as collateral. You made Iron Man in a building with a car dealership underneath it. You cast a Donohue Channel kid as Tony Stark, a sketch comedian as the Hulk, and a woman nobody believed in as Thor. You did it without anybody's help. Including mine.

A ripple through the room. A few people glance at each other.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
So here's what's going to change. The bank won't own your heroes anymore. That's it. That's the list.

Silence. People blink.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
You'll stay in this building, if you want to. Kevin runs the studio. Nobody from Burbank will tell you who to cast, what to write or which comic to adapt. If anyone from Donohue ever tries, you call Lenora, and Lenora calls me, and that person will be looking for a new job by lunch.

(beat, a small smile)
Including if it's my son.

Laughter breaks the tension. Lenora, beside Feige, folds her arms and nods approvingly.

VFX SUPERVISOR (40s)
(calling out)
Mrs. Bullock? Are you going to make Thor a musical?

NATASHA
Only if Esther Smilley wants to sing. And from what I hear, she's done singing to goats.

A big laugh. The room relaxes visibly. Natasha turns to Feige and holds out her hand.

NATASHA (CONT'D)
Kevin. Thank you for building something worth protecting.

Feige takes her hand. Then, impulsively, the president of Marvel Studios reaches under his desk and pulls out a battered, plastic-sleeved TALES OF SUSPENSE #39. The first printing he held at Marc-Anthony's screen test.

FEIGE
This was the first thing I ever bought with my own money. I was nine. I want you to hold it.

Natasha takes the comic carefully in both hands, as if it were made of glass. She looks down at the cover: Iron Man, gray and clunky, 1963.

NATASHA
(quietly)
It doesn't leave the sleeve, I assume.

FEIGE
It doesn't leave the sleeve.

CUT TO:

INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - KITCHEN - VIEW PARK - MORNING

SUPER: MONDAY, AUGUST 31, 2009 - 7:20 A.M. PDT

A replay of May 5th, but worse. DESMOND (51) stands at the island in his bathrobe, CNBC playing on the small kitchen TV: "DONOHUE TO BUY MARVEL FOR $4B." CELESTE (49), JULIAN (32) and SIMONE (30) sit at the table. HATTIE (74) stands in the doorway. ESTHER (26) sits very still, holding a mug of tea she isn't drinking.

DESMOND
You will call Kevin Feige today. You will tell him you've had a change of heart. You will withdraw from THOR.

ESTHER
No, Daddy.

DESMOND
Esther. Look at that screen. As of this morning, you work for Natasha Bullock. Your name will be on a Donohue paycheck. Your face will be on Donohue lunchboxes. Your great-great-grandfather built that company's soul with his savings and they threw him out. And you want to work for them?

ESTHER
I work for Kevin Feige. I worked for him yesterday and I'll work for him tomorrow. The press release says Donohue has no role in casting. Nobody gets uncast.

DESMOND
(bitter laugh)
And you believe Natasha Bullock? You believe a press release?

Esther looks at her father. She doesn't answer. Because she doesn't believe the press release. She believes the man who made his mother promise twice. She can't say that.

ESTHER
I believe Kevin.

DESMOND
Then believe this. If you stay in that movie, you are choosing them over us.

The kitchen goes silent. Celeste gasps softly.

SIMONE
(standing)
Daddy, that's not fair...

DESMOND
Fair? FAIR? Was it fair in 1966? Was it fair in 1989, when Robert Bullock called me a frame with no painting in it? Was it fair when Natasha stole half our clients in 1997?

ESTHER
(quiet, standing too)
None of that happened to me, Daddy.

DESMOND
It happened to your FAMILY.

ESTHER
Then maybe it's time somebody in our family let it stop happening.

A long, frozen silence. Desmond stares at his youngest daughter. Then, without another word, he turns and walks out of the kitchen. They hear the front door slam. Then a car engine. Then nothing.

Hattie walks slowly to the table and sits down beside Esther. She takes the mug of cold tea out of her granddaughter's trembling hands and holds them.

HATTIE
(softly)
Your grandfather said the same thing to his father in 1979. Right before Zeke died. "Let it stop."

ESTHER
(barely audible)
What happened?

HATTIE
Zeke made us all swear the Oath instead.

(beat)
Your grandfather has regretted it for thirty years.

CUT TO:

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - GUEST COLUMN - FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 4, 2009

THE HOUSE THAT DONOHUE BOUGHT

By Desmond Smilley

Last Monday, the largest entertainment company on Earth swallowed another one. We are told nothing will change. We are told Marvel will remain "independent." We were told that in 1966, too, when a young Victor Donohue absorbed my family's production company "as a partnership." Forty-three years later, my father is still waiting for his partner to call.

Hollywood should be very afraid of a world where one family owns the parks, the networks, the music, the sports, the cartoons, and now the superheroes. When the regulators review this deal, I hope they ask one simple question: who is left to say no to Donohue?

I am proud of my daughter. I wish she were working anywhere else.

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY - FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 4, 2009, 11:00 AM PT

DESMOND SMILLEY GOES NUCLEAR IN THR - AND TAKES A SHOT AT HIS OWN DAUGHTER?

"I am proud of my daughter. I wish she were working anywhere else." Ouch. That's the last line of Desmond Smilley's guest column. I'm told Esther Smilley read it on set at a Thor costume fitting and walked out to her car for twenty minutes. Meanwhile, federal regulators have opened a routine antitrust review of the deal. Insiders tell me Smilley's lawyers have been "in touch."

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ESTATE - VICTOR'S STUDY - BEL AIR - DAY

SUPER: FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 4, 2009 - 2:00 P.M. PDT

VICTOR (73) sits at his desk, reading the column in a print copy of THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER. JOAN (71) stands beside him. He reaches the line: "my father is still waiting for his partner to call."

He sets the magazine down very carefully.

VICTOR
"Still waiting for his partner to call."

JOAN
Desmond doesn't know about the phone, Victor. About election night.

VICTOR
But Cornelius does.

A long silence. Joan looks at the safe in the corner of the study. Then at her husband.

JOAN
It's been forty-three years.

VICTOR
I know how long it's been.

JOAN
The boy is going to read that column. Esther Smilley read it on a costume fitting. Our grandson is in love with her, Victor. You know he is.

Victor looks up sharply.

VICTOR
You know that?

JOAN
(a small, sad smile)
I watched him at dinner on Sunday. "Not against anyone. Including people this family doesn't like." I've known for a year.

(beat)
So does Natasha. She just hasn't let herself say it yet.

Victor looks out the window at his gardens for a very long time.

VICTOR
(quietly)
Not yet, Joan. Not yet.

JOAN
That's what you said in 1967.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - SEPTEMBER TO DECEMBER 2009

VARIETY - SEPTEMBER 2009

'THOR' BEGINS PREP IN NORWAY UNDER NEW OWNERSHIP; SMILLEY REMAINS ATTACHED

"Esther never wavered," says a Marvel source. "Not for one day."

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL - DECEMBER 2009

Federal Regulators Clear Donohue-Marvel Deal Without Conditions

Regulators found no antitrust concerns; the agreement's "casting firewall" clause was cited by Donohue's lawyers as evidence of Marvel's continued independence.

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "IT'S BEEN 3 MONTHS. HAS DONOHUE RUINED MARVEL?" (Page 1 of 12)

ShellHead1963 (Dec 17, 10:00 AM)
Iron Man 2 trailer dropped. It's incredible. No Mickey ears. Thor is shooting on location in Norway. Feige is still Feige. The answer is no.

NoNerfsPlz (Dec 17, 10:04 AM)
Also they paid off the bank debt. Marvel is now the most financially stable studio in Hollywood. The Avengers is happening for SURE now.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Dec 17, 10:20 AM)
My dad works in finance. He says Donohue spent $4B on Marvel and Marvel's going to make that back in like three movies. Natasha Bullock is a genius and also terrifying.

CUT TO:

INT. MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT - SHAREHOLDER MEETING - NEW YORK CITY - DAY

SUPER: THURSDAY, DECEMBER 31, 2009 - 10:00 A.M. EST

A modest hotel ballroom in Midtown. A sparse crowd of shareholders, lawyers and a few reporters. On the dais, Marvel's board. A CORPORATE SECRETARY (50s) reads from a sheet.

CORPORATE SECRETARY
...the merger agreement has been approved by holders of a majority of the outstanding shares of Marvel Entertainment. The transaction is expected to close this afternoon.

A smattering of polite applause. A reporter types into a BlackBerry.

DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT, INC. - PRESS RELEASE - DECEMBER 31, 2009, 4:30 PM ET

DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT COMPLETES ACQUISITION OF MARVEL ENTERTAINMENT

Marvel's film credit facility has been retired in full.

CUT TO:

EXT. DONOHUE ESTATE - TERRACE - BEL AIR - NIGHT

SUPER: THURSDAY, DECEMBER 31, 2009 - 11:58 P.M. PST - NEW YEAR'S EVE

The whole family on the terrace in coats, champagne in hand, watching fireworks begin to bloom over the city. VICTOR (73), JOAN (71), NATASHA (48), ROBERT (50), ELXA (29), GRACE (15) with sparkling cider, and MARC-ANTHONY (27).

VICTOR
(raising his glass)
To the Avengers. Whoever they turn out to be.

GRACE
We KNOW who they turn out to be, Grandpa. There's a Facebook group with a million people in it.

Laughter. The countdown begins on a radio inside. TEN. NINE. EIGHT. Marc-Anthony steps a few feet away from the family to the edge of the terrace. He takes out his phone.

SEVEN. SIX. FIVE. Natasha watches him go. Joan watches Natasha watching him.

FOUR. THREE. TWO.

ONE. Fireworks explode over Los Angeles. Everybody cheers. Marc-Anthony is looking at his phone.

TEXT MESSAGE - "PASTOR WILLIAMS" TO MARC

FRI 1/1/10 12:00 AM

happy new year marc. 2010. i leave for norway in 6 days. i'm going to be a god. are u going to be in london for the avengers stuff?

TEXT MESSAGE - MARC TO "PASTOR WILLIAMS"

FRI 1/1/10 12:01 AM

happy new year esther. i'll be wherever ur not supposed to be. that's kind of our thing

TEXT MESSAGE - "PASTOR WILLIAMS" TO MARC

FRI 1/1/10 12:02 AM

2010. new decade. maybe this is the decade we stop hiding

Marc-Anthony stares at that message. Behind him, his family laughs and toasts. Fireworks paint the sky gold and red.

NATASHA (O.S.)
Marc! Come back! Your grandfather's about to make a speech!

He types one more message, quickly.

TEXT MESSAGE - MARC TO "PASTOR WILLIAMS"

FRI 1/1/10 12:03 AM

maybe

He puts the phone in his pocket and turns back to his family. Natasha is looking right at him with an expression he can't read. He smiles and joins them.

Above Los Angeles, the fireworks keep falling.

FADE OUT.

HEADLINES

VARIETY - MONDAY, JANUARY 4, 2010

A NEW DECADE, A NEW MARVEL

With Donohue's deal complete and its bank debt gone, Marvel enters 2010 with "Iron Man 2" in May, "Thor" filming in Norway, and "Captain America" casting underway. One question remains: who will wear the shield?

JET MAGAZINE - "PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT" (Issue of Jan. 18, 2010)

The Donohues Ring in 2010 with Marvel in Their Pocket

Meanwhile, in View Park, a source says Desmond Smilley spent New Year's Eve alone in his study. His daughter Esther leaves for Norway this week to begin filming "Thor" for her new boss: Natasha Bullock.

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER TEN